Production document

Development Plan

Scope, roadmap, technical architecture, game systems, assets, resources and open questions for a solo developer.

Engine	Babylon.js 9 (TypeScript) · WebGPU + WebGL2
Team	Solo developer
First milestone	Episode 1 release (about 31 weeks)
Version	2.0 · October 2026
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01 Key Decisions

This plan turns the proposal and the five episode specifications into a plan one person can carry out. These decisions are fixed unless deliberately revisited.

Decision	Choice	Reason
Team	Solo developer	Sized for one person; art and audio come from libraries plus targeted custom work.
Engine	Babylon.js (TypeScript)	Mature WebGPU with WebGL2 fallback from one codebase, built-in Havok physics, spatial audio, inspector, no editor lock-in.
Assets	Libraries + custom Blender work	Generic props from CC0 or paid libraries; Khmer-specific hero assets made custom.
First milestone	Episode 1 released on its own	Proves the technology, tone and pipeline before committing to four more episodes.
Episode length	1.5–2.5 hours each, 8–10 hours total	Short, dense episodes (5–6 puzzles, 3–4 escalating encounters, one optional area, one key choice) are better for players and achievable alone.

Versions checked (October 2026)

Package	Version
`@babylonjs/core`, `@babylonjs/loaders`	9.31.0
`@babylonjs/havok`	1.3.14
`vite`	8.3.4
`typescript`	7.0.2
Node.js (installed)	26.8.2

Pin exact versions in `package.json` when the project is created, and upgrade deliberately.

02 Scope and Roadmap

2.1 The honest size of the project

The original proposal budgeted 11 months for a five-person team, roughly 55 person-months. With the shorter, denser episodes chosen in v3.0 (8–10 hours in total instead of 15–20), a solo developer should expect about **2–2.5 years** at 25 hours per week. To keep it achievable:

1. **Ship Episode 1 alone first**, as a free or pay-what-you-want release, to test the idea with real players.
2. **Build every system once** in Episode 1 and reuse it in Episodes 2–5.
3. **Cut cost, not atmosphere.** Darkness, fog, sound and first-person framing hide a lot.

Estimates assume about 25 focused hours per week. Scale them to your real availability.

PHASE 0	PHASE 1	PHASE 2
Pre-production	**Technical spikes**	**Greybox**
3 weeks	4 weeks	4 weeks

PHASE 3	PHASE 4	PHASE 5
Core systems	**Art and audio**	**Polish and release**
7 weeks	8 weeks	5 weeks

Total: about 31 weeks (7–8 months) to the Episode 1 release. Episodes 2–5 then take about 3–4 months each.

2.2 Phases and exit criteria

Each phase ends with a checklist. Don't start the next phase until it passes, unless you consciously accept the gap.

Phase 0 · Pre-production — 3 weeks

Task	Output
Review the Story Bible with a cultural advisor; resolve remaining open questions (section 6)	Approved story
Write the Episode 1 beat sheet: every scene, trigger, item and line in order	Episode 1 beat sheet
Define the fail state (what happens when Sora is caught)	Short specification
Build a visual reference board: 1930s Battambang houses, funeral tents, lamps, clothing	Reference folder with sources
Write a one-page art bible: palette, lighting rules, post-processing, texture density	Art bible

Task	Output
Install the toolchain (section 5.1)	Working Blender → glb → browser pipeline
Work through the Babylon.js getting-started docs and playground	Comfort with scenes, cameras, lights, materials, loaders

Exit: you can describe all of Episode 1 from start to end without opening the specification.

Phase 1 · Technical spikes

4 weeks

Small throwaway prototypes that answer risky technical questions before they become expensive.

Spike	Question	Pass condition
S1 First-person controller	Does movement feel right on raised floors, stairs and ladders?	Walk, crouch, climb stairs, head-bob; no snagging on 1 cm floor gaps
S2 Lamp lighting	Can one shadowed lamp and many small flames run on a laptop?	30 fps at 720p on integrated graphics with 1 shadowed light and 20+ flame lights
S3 Asset pipeline	Can a Blender model reach the browser compressed?	.blend → .glb → Draco/meshopt + KTX2 → loads with correct materials
S4 Spatial audio	Can players locate an unseen enemy by sound?	Eyes closed, you can point to a footstep source
S5 Diegetic sketchbook	Can a 3D book show readable, updatable pages?	Open, flip, new note appears; readable at 720p
S6 Save and load	Does state survive a refresh and export as a code?	Save, reload, restore; export and import a save code
S7 Atmosphere	Can the 1930s look be done cheaply?	Grain, vignette, aberration, sepia grade and fog within budget
S8 WebGPU / WebGL2	Does the same build run on both?	Same scene runs in Chrome with WebGPU on and off

Exit: all spikes pass, or the design is adjusted (for example, fewer shadowed lights).

Phase 2 · Episode 1 greybox

4 weeks

Build the whole episode from grey boxes: no final art, but every room at the right scale and every trigger, puzzle, enemy path, line of text and the dawn key choice in place. Target: 1.5–2 hours for a first-time player.

Exit: a friend can play Episode 1 start to finish, and it is scary even with boxes. If it isn't, fix the pacing now; art will not save it.

Phase 3 · Core systems — 7 weeks

Turn the spike code into reusable systems (section 4): interaction, inventory, sketchbook, lamp and resources, stealth perception, entity AI, scripted events, saves, settings and accessibility. Add automated tests for game logic.

Exit: adding a new item, note or trigger means editing data, not engine code.

Phase 4 · Art and audio — 8 weeks

Weeks	Focus
1–2	Hero architecture: stilt house, funeral tent, under-house area, shed
3–4	Props (library assets retextured, custom Khmer props, betel tray set) and characters (Yay Mey, Vuthy, the corpse, the entity)
5	Lighting bake, post-processing, rain and wind effects
6–7	Sound: ambience, foley, horror cues, entity sounds, music
8	Performance pass: draw calls, polygons, texture memory, load size

Exit: meets the performance budgets (section 3.5) on both reference machines.

Phase 5 · Polish, test, release — 5 weeks

- Five or more outside playtesters; watch without helping and note where they get lost or bored.
- Cultural review by at least one Cambodian advisor.
- Browser testing: Chrome, Edge, Firefox and Safari on Windows and macOS.
- Store or landing page, trailer capture, release.

Exit: Episode 1 is public. Collect feedback before starting Episode 2.

2.3 Episodes 2–5

Episode	New systems	Reused	Estimate
2 · Whispering Pagoda	Lamp shutter, surface noise, breath, distractions, mirror beams, playable flashback (alternate hands and pace), timed escape	Everything from Episode 1	3–4 months

Episode	New systems	Reused	Estimate
3 · Drowned Village	Daylight lighting and simple NPCs, rowboat, wetness, safe-zone lights, water-only enemy	Fuses reuse the key-fragment pattern	3.5–4 months
4 · Rubber Plantation	Compass, fog loop, voice-mimic taboo, companion AI (follow, wait, carry light), furnace sequence	Gears reuse inventory slots	3–4 months
5 · Sunken Sanctuary	Hub with escalation, boss ritual, chant choices, ending resolver	Each trial reuses an earlier system	3.5–4 months

2.4 Solo cut list

If time runs short, cut from the top. None of these damages the core experience.

1. Spoken dialogue → written text, with Khmer voice for key lines only.
2. Full-body characters → Sora is hands-only; NPCs mostly seated, still or in silhouette.
3. Many unique props → fewer props, varied with material tints and decals.
4. Physics-driven debris in escapes → scripted animation.
5. Rowboat physics (Episode 3) → boat on a path with limited steering.
6. Daylight market crowd (Episode 3) → a few static vendors and ambient sound.

> **AVOID AS A SOLO DEVELOPER**
>
> - Building a level editor: use Blender as the level editor and export metadata with custom properties.
> - Writing engine features Babylon.js already has (physics, audio, picking, GUI, post-processing).
> - Starting Episode 2 content before Episode 1 is released.
> - Polishing art in a room whose gameplay is not final.

03 Technical Architecture

3.1 Stack

Layer	Choice	Notes
Language	TypeScript (strict)	Babylon.js itself is written in TypeScript
Build	Vite	Fast dev server; static build output
Engine	`@babylonjs/core` (ES modules)	Import only what is used to keep the bundle small
Loaders	`@babylonjs/loaders` (glTF 2.0)	Draco/meshopt and KTX2 decoders loaded on demand
Rendering	WebGPU with WebGL2 fallback	Detect support at startup and create the matching engine
Physics	Havok	Character controller, collisions, triggers
Audio	Babylon.js Audio Engine v2	Spatial sound, buses, reverb; unlocked on first click
Interface	Babylon GUI on meshes + dynamic textures	Diegetic sketchbook and gauges; HTML only for menus and loading
Navigation	Recast navmesh plugin	Enemy pathing (check current docs for the package)
Storage	IndexedDB	Save slots and settings
Tests	Vitest; Playwright smoke test	Test game logic, not rendering
Assets	Blender → glTF → glTF-Transform	One command rebuilds all assets
Hosting	Static host (Cloudflare Pages, Netlify, GitHub Pages, itch.io)	Check per-file size limits
Source control	Git + Git LFS	LFS for .blend, .wav and other binary sources

3.2 Repository layout

```
/
├── docs/                Design documents, PDFs, sources
├── art-source/          .blend, textures, raw audio (Git LFS)
├── tools/               Asset and document build scripts
├── public/assets/
│   ├── shared/          Lamp, hands, satchel, sketchbook, common sounds
│   └── ep1/             Episode 1 compressed models, textures, audio
├── src/
│   ├── main.ts          Boot: detect WebGPU, create engine, load menu
│   ├── core/            Engine wrapper, scene manager, loader, event bus
│   ├── player/          Controller, camera, interaction, hands
│   ├── systems/         Inventory, sketchbook, lamp, stealth, save, settings
│   ├── ai/              Perception, state machines, entity types
│   ├── audio/           Audio setup, buses, ambience zones, cues
│   ├── render/          Post-processing, materials, quality presets
│   ├── ui/              Diegetic widgets, HTML menus
│   ├── episodes/ep1/    Scene setup, scripted events, puzzles, data
│   └── data/            Shared item, note and dialogue definitions
└── tests/
```

3.3 Core architecture

Principle: systems are generic; episodes are data plus a few scripts.

Part	How it works
Event bus	Systems never call each other directly. The lamp announces `lamp:extinguished`; the AI listens and lowers visibility. This keeps systems reusable.
Game flags	One key-value store holds all story progress (for example `ep1.gramophone.solved`). Saves serialise it; Episode 5 reads flags from Episodes 1–4.
Scripted sequences	Written as readable async functions (walk to, play sound, wait for look), so no visual scripting tool is needed.
State machines	Entities and puzzles use small explicit state machines (idle → patrol → investigate → chase → lose track) in plain TypeScript.
Blender as level editor	Triggers, spawn points, patrol nodes, hiding spots and audio zones are empties with custom properties, exported to glTF and turned into game objects by the loader.
Area streaming	Each episode is split into areas loaded and unloaded as asset containers. Shared assets stay loaded; unloaded areas dispose their meshes, materials and textures.

3.4 Rendering

Feature	Approach
Lamp light	One point light with shadows; usually the only dynamic shadow caster.

Feature	Approach
Candles and small flames	Unshadowed point lights with flicker, emissive meshes and glow; test Babylon 9's clustered lighting in spike S2.
Static lighting	Baked lightmaps or ambient occlusion from Blender for architecture.
Fog	Scene fog plus animated fog cards near the player; a volumetric shader only if it fits the budget (important for Episode 4).
Post-processing	Grain, chromatic aberration, vignette, bloom and colour grading (a sepia look for Episode 1).
Special materials	Node Material Editor for the entity shadow, wet surfaces, blood on the map and glowing runes.
Quality presets	Low / Medium / High, chosen automatically from a quick benchmark on first launch.

3.5 Performance budgets

Budget	Target	How to check
Frame rate	60 fps at 1080p (dedicated GPU) · 30 fps at 720p (integrated)	Babylon Inspector on a real integrated-graphics laptop
Draw calls	120 or fewer	Inspector statistics; instancing and merged meshes
Visible polygons	150,000 or fewer	Inspector; LODs on large props
Initial download	85 MB or less per episode; first area under 20 MB	Browser network tab with cache disabled
Texture memory	About 256 MB per area	KTX2 everywhere; 2K hero, 1K or 512 props
JavaScript bundle	3 MB or less (gzipped)	Vite build report

Choose two reference machines on day one (your main computer and an inexpensive integrated-graphics laptop) and test on both every week.

3.6 Save system

What is saved	Episode, area, checkpoint, flags, inventory, sketchbook entries, resource levels, settings and ending counters (taboos broken, lore notes found).
When	Fixed checkpoints and episode completion; no free saving, which keeps the tension.
Where	IndexedDB, three slots, versioned, with migrations for future changes.
Save codes	JSON → compressed → URL-safe base64 with a checksum, for moving progress between devices and into the next episode.

Security note	Browser-side encryption cannot stop a determined player because the key ships with the game. Save codes are tamper-evident, not secret, which is fine for a single-player game.

3.7 Browser support

Browser	Expected path
Chrome, Edge	WebGPU
Safari	WebGPU on macOS 26+; WebGL2 on older macOS
Firefox	WebGPU on Windows and Apple Silicon Macs; WebGL2 elsewhere
Mobile	Not supported; show a friendly message

3.8 Input and accessibility

- Keyboard and mouse first; gamepad support through the Gamepad API.
- Rebindable keys, mouse sensitivity, invert Y, field-of-view slider.
- Subtitles and captions for important sounds, with a visual-cue option for deaf and hard-of-hearing players.
- Toggles for head-bob, film grain and chromatic aberration (motion sickness and comfort).
- Brightness calibration screen.
- English and Khmer text from the start, with all strings stored in data files.

04 Game Systems

4.1 System matrix

Every mechanic from the five episodes, with the episode that first needs it. Build each system once and extend it.

System	Ep	Reused in	Build notes
First-person controller	1	All	Havok character controller; crouch lowers camera and noise
Interaction raycast	1	All	Ray from screen centre; feedback on the hands, never a HUD crosshair
Inventory (satchel)	1	All	Data-driven items; satchel opens in front of the camera
Sketchbook	1	All	3D book; pages rendered to texture; entries unlocked by flags
Kerosene lamp	1	All	Oil gauge is a mesh on the lamp; refills are pickups
Matches	1	5	Count shown on the matchbox
Timed upkeep (incense)	1	5	Generic decaying resource: timer, warnings, consequence
Hiding spots	1	2, 4	Trigger volume + lamp off = hidden
Perception: sight	1	All	View cone + line-of-sight ray; lamp light raises visibility
Perception: hearing	1	All	Noise events with loudness and radius
Moves when unwatched	1	5	Checks camera view and occlusion
"Do not turn around"	1	4, 5	Tracks camera rotation against a reference direction
Scripted sequences	1	All	Async scripts reading and writing flags
Puzzle framework	1	All	Slots, dials, combinations
Ritual sequence	1	3, 4, 5	Ordered steps with a timer and failure handling
Checkpoints and saves	1	All	See section 3.6
Night count	1	All	Seven circles in the sketchbook; one filled per episode
Choices and counters	1	All	Respect, knowledge, Vuthy; stored in flags and save codes
Lamp shutter	2	3, 4, 5	Lamp states: open / shuttered / out

System	Ep	Reused in	Build notes
Surface noise	2	All	Material tags on ground meshes
Hold breath	2	5	Short timed action with recovery
Throwable distractions	2	3, 4	Physics throw + noise event on impact
Mirror light beams	2	5	Reflected raycasts between rotatable mirrors
Timed escapes	2	3, 4	Scripted hazards with a checkpoint at the start
Playable flashback / memory	2	3 (Sok), 5 (memories)	Swap hands model, speed and post-processing; no fail state
Daylight scene and NPCs	3	—	Second lighting preset; simple talk-to NPCs
Rowboat	3	—	Simplest viable version first
Wetness and temperature	3	—	Drains in water, recovers near heat
Safe-zone lights	3	4	Area that repels an entity type
Sealing windows	3	—	Puzzle slots that change a room's flooding
Water-only enemy	3	—	Separate navmesh of water surfaces
Compass	4	5	Needle follows world north
Fog loop	4	—	Wrong turns quietly loop the player
Voice-mimic taboo	4	—	Turning or noise counts as answering
Furnace and valves	4	—	Resource-juggling ritual variant
Crawling	4	5	Extends crouch; forced slow speed
Companion AI	4	—	Follow, wait, carry a light; never speaks from behind the player
Telephone interlude	4	—	Short dialogue scene with one unscored choice
Hub with trials	5	—	Flags per trial; difficulty scales with trials completed
Chant choices	5	—	Choices drawn in the sketchbook
Boss ritual	5	—	Ritual sequence + entity attacks
Ending resolver	5	—	Three endings from chant errors, respect and Vuthy (section 4.3)

4.2 Fail state

The episode specifications never said what happens when Sora fails. Recommended:

- Caught → short scare, fade to black, a page torn from the sketchbook, restart at the last checkpoint.

- No health bar. Episode 5's shadow damage is shown by darkening and sound, with two or three hits before failure.
- Running out of oil doesn't kill; it makes the dark more dangerous.

4.3 Cross-episode tracking

Counter	Example sources
Respect (0–9)	Ep 1: betel tray, incense (+2) · Ep 2: offerings, honest memory, names at dawn (+3) · Ep 3: mother freed (+2) · Ep 4: no taboo broken, boundary stones (+2)
Knowledge	About 5 lore notes per episode; they confirm the true chant lines in Episode 5
Vuthy	Journal shared (Ep 1, dialogue only) · saved (Ep 4) · forgiven (Ep 5)
Chant errors	Wrong verses in Episode 5, Phase 2
Endings	3+ chant errors → Bound to the Soil · otherwise respect ≥ 6 + Vuthy saved + forgiven → The Unbroken Freedom · otherwise → The Last Payment

4.4 Entity catalogue

Entity	Ep	Senses	Behaviour	Counter-play
Neak Ta shadow	1–5	Sight + hearing; stronger each episode	Mostly scripted; roams set areas	Darkness, hiding, rituals
Shadow roamer	1	Mostly hearing	Patrol and investigate noise	Quiet movement, lamp off
Pret	2, 5	Hearing only	Patrol stupa paths; drawn to offerings	Crouch, soft ground, breath, distractions
Chhlong Tonle	3	Senses the player in water	Moves only through water	Stay dry, safe-zone lights
Khmaoch Prey	4	Looking back or replying	Mimics voices from behind	Walk on, don't turn, stay silent
Neak Ta Guardian	5	Full awareness	Area attacks, tendrils	Complete the ritual while evading

05 Assets and Resources

5.1 Tools

Purpose	Tool	Cost	Notes
Code editor	VS Code	Free	
3D, UVs, baking, level layout	Blender (latest LTS)	Free	Not installed yet
Asset compression	glTF-Transform CLI	Free	Draco/meshopt, KTX2, resizing
KTX2 encoder	KTX-Software (Khronos)	Free	Used by glTF-Transform
Texture painting	Krita · Substance 3D Painter	Free / paid	ArmorPaint, Material Maker as open alternatives
Image editing	GIMP · Photopea	Free	
Audio editing	Audacity · Reaper	Free / ~US$60	
Recording	USB microphone, quiet room	—	Foley is cheap to record yourself
Binary version control	Git LFS	Free	Not installed yet
Babylon tools	Playground, Sandbox, Node Material Editor, Inspector	Free	Browser-based

5.2 Episode 1 asset list

Source: **C** custom (Blender) · **L** library asset, retextured · **K** kitbash · **R** record yourself.

ENVIRONMENTS

Asset	Source	Priority	Notes
Phnom Penh studio interior	K	High	Small room; reuse furniture later
Village path and banana grove	K	Medium	Instanced banana plants; mostly darkness and rain
Courtyard ground, mud, puddles	C	High	Wet mud material is a key visual
Teak stilt house (exterior, hall, Sok's room)	C	Critical	Modular kit: planks with gaps, walls, posts, stairs, roof, shutters
Under-house area and storage shed	C	High	Reuses house pillars
White funeral tent	C	Critical	Bamboo frame; cloth with wind animation

PROPS, CHARACTERS AND AUDIO

Asset	Source	Notes
Teak coffin and stage	C	Hero prop; also used in the bad ending
Altar, portrait frame, brass candle holders	C / L	Portrait texture swaps for the "eyes open" scare
Four brass incense burners and sticks	C	Burn-down shader on sticks
Protective white thread	C	Snaps in two
Oil lamps, candles	C / L	Emissive flame card + flicker light
Clay jars, bamboo benches, mats	C / L	2–3 variants, instanced
Gramophone with speed dial	L + edits	Adjust to the period
Desk, pens, palm-leaf manuscripts	L / C	
Iron-bound chest, loose planks, wardrobes	C / L	Wardrobes are hiding spots
Telephone, wall clock, drafting table	L	Prologue
Player items: lamp, matchbox, satchel, sketchbook, key fragments, Bronze Token	C	Seen up close all game; most detail
First-person hands	C / L	No full body needed
Yay Mey	L + custom	White mourning clothes; few animations
Vuthy	L + custom	1930s town suit; standing and talking only in Episode 1
Betel tray set (leaves, areca, lime pot, tray)	C	Puzzle props; check against reference
Uncle Sok's corpse	C / L	Lying pose only
Neak Ta entity and shadow roamer	C	Mostly shader silhouette plus a detailed brass mask
Ambience beds	L + R	Rain, thunder, insects, frogs, wind, roof tiles
Foley	R	Footsteps on teak, dirt and mud; cloth; pages; matches; creaks
Horror cues	R + design	Backward chant, clock, thread snap, dragging steps, whispers, static
Music	Commission / licence	Sparse Pinpeat-inspired tones and drones
Voice	Khmer voice actors	Phone call and key lines, English subtitles

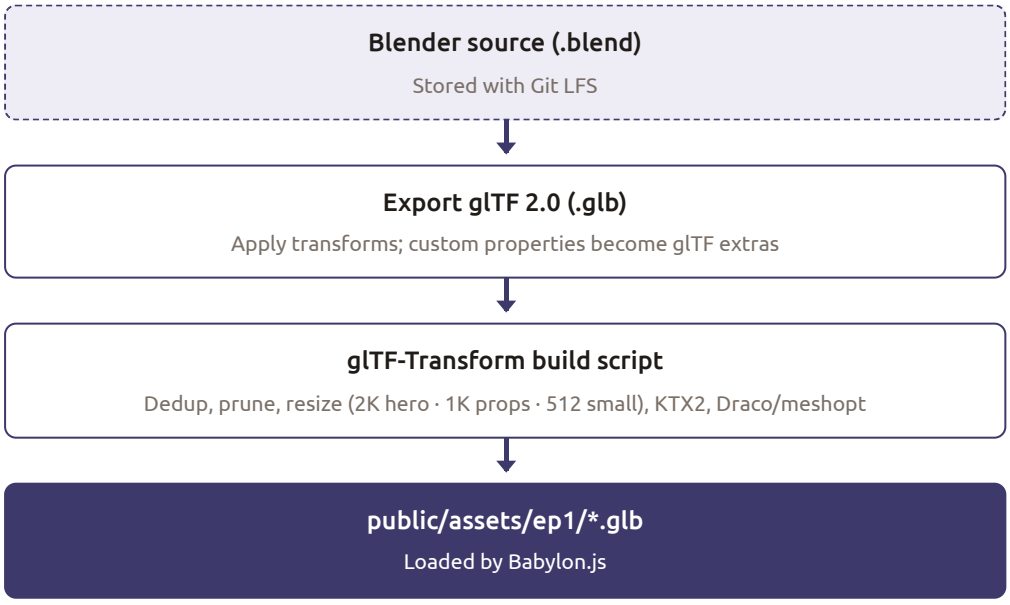
5.3 Asset sources

Check the licence of each individual asset and keep a credits file listing source, author, licence and link.

Source	What	Licence notes
Poly Haven	Textures, HDRIs, some models	CC0
ambientCG	PBR textures	CC0
Sketchfab	Models, including some Southeast Asian items	Mixed; filter CC0/CC-BY and credit authors
Fab (Epic)	Megascans and marketplace	Megascans no longer free after 2024; check the current licence
Freesound	Sound effects	Per-sound CC licences
Sonniss GameAudioGDC bundles	Large royalty-free SFX packs	Free; check the included licence
Mixamo	Rigging and animations	Free with an Adobe account; check terms
Google Fonts	Khmer fonts: Noto Serif Khmer, Battambang, Moul, Koulen, Preahvihear	Open Font License

> **RULE OF THUMB**
> Use library assets for generic objects (furniture, tools, textures) and custom work for anything that makes the game Cambodian: architecture, ritual objects, clothing and the entity. Players notice the second group.

5.4 Asset pipeline



Naming: `ep1_house_wall_a.glb`, `shared_lamp.glb`; Blender empties named `trigger_*`, `spawn_*`, `patrol_*`, `hide_*`, `audio_zone_*` become game objects.

5.5 Learning resources

Topic	Where
Babylon.js fundamentals	doc.babylonjs.com (Getting Started, then Features); playground.babylonjs.com
Help and community	forum.babylonjs.com
WebGPU, physics, audio	doc.babylonjs.com: WebGPU, Physics V2 (character controller), Audio
Shaders without code	nme.babylonjs.com (Node Material Editor)
glTF optimisation	gltf-transform.dev
Blender for games	Blender manual; modular environment and trim-sheet tutorials
Horror design	Play and study *Amnesia: The Dark Descent*, *Fatal Frame*, *Home Sweet Home*, *Pamali*, *DreadOut*; GDC talks on horror pacing and audio
Web performance	Babylon.js "Optimizing your scene"; browser performance tools

5.6 Cultural and historical research

Topic	Sources to start with
Neak Ta and Khmer spirits	Ang Choulean, *Les êtres surnaturels dans la religion populaire khmère* (Paris, CEDORECK, 1986). Neak Ta are usually protective guardians, often represented by stones.
Colonial economy and plantations	Margaret Slocomb, *An Economic History of Cambodia in the Twentieth Century* (NUS Press, 2010; open access via OAPEN); Michitake Aso, "Rubber and Race in Rural Colonial Cambodia (1920s–1954)".
Historical photographs	Gallica (Bibliothèque nationale de France), Archives nationales d'outre-mer (ANOM), École française d'Extrême-Orient (EFEO), Bophana Audiovisual Resource Center.
Funerals, Pchum Ben, offerings	Ethnographic literature plus interviews with elders and monks (with permission).
Pinpeat music	Cambodian Living Arts and Cambodian musicians; commission or license recordings rather than imitating them.
Language	A native Khmer speaker to check every Khmer term and translate in-game text.

ADVISOR PLAN

Find one or two Cambodian advisors in Phase 0 (a family elder, a university contact or a cultural organisation). Schedule reviews of the story outline, the Episode 1 greybox and the release candidate. Credit them in the game.

5.7 Rough budget (Episode 1)

Item	Low	Comfortable
Software	US$0	~US$300
Paid assets	US$0–100	~US$400
Sound and music	US$0	US$500–1,500
Voice acting	US$0	US$200–600
Cultural advisor honorarium	—	US$200–500
Integrated-graphics test laptop	—	US$300–500 used
Hosting	US$0	US$0–20 / month

06 Open Questions

Found by reading the proposal and all five episode specifications together. Each episode document also lists its own open issues.

6.1 Story and continuity

#	Issue	When	Suggested resolution
Q1	The Silver Betel Box is never destroyed or cleansed, yet Episode 5 needs its "inlay"	Done	Dawn offering at Chea's stupa added in v3.0
Q2	Two versions of the pact: forest altar (Ep 2) vs estate contract (Ep 4)	Done	1910 forest shrine; the estate was built over it in 1923
Q3	A working rubber estate in 1910 is historically early	Done	Resolved by Q2
Q4	Sora's parents are missing; Yay Mey's place in the bloodline is unclear	Done	Kanha was the third payment (1920); father Rith died 1929; Yay Mey married in
Q5	Clinic timeline (1920 vs "decades ago" vs 1925 photo)	Done	Kanha drowned in 1920; Sok returned in 1931; photo dated 1920
Q6	Time between episodes is never stated	Done	Seven-night countdown: Nights 1, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7
Q7	Time mismatches in v1 headers; sunrise at 4:00 AM	Done	Corrected in the v2.0 episode documents
Q8	The Episode 1 map already shows all four locations	Done	Four faint marks, revealed one at a time
Q9	What happened to Kanha's baby in 1920?	Before Ep 3	Lost with her, or a sibling Sora never knew

6.2 Gameplay

#	Issue	When	Suggested resolution
G1	No fail state defined	Done	Checkpoint restart, no health bar (section 4.2)
G2	Ending conditions aren't tracked in Episodes 1–4	Done	Respect, knowledge and Vuthy counters; one key choice per episode (section 4.3)
G3	Checkpoints only, or manual saves too?	Before Ep 1	Checkpoints only
G4	Single difficulty or a story mode?	Before release	A story mode helps players who come for the culture and narrative

#	Issue	When	Suggested resolution
G5	"Hand-crank lantern" in Episode 4	Done	Changed to an oil lantern in v2.0
G6	"Kerosene spotlights" in Episode 3	Done	Changed to fixed wall lamps in v2.0
G7	Pret appear in the Episode 5 Wind trial	Before Ep 5	Fine as a callback; explain in the sketchbook

6.3 Presentation, culture and business

#	Issue	When	Suggested resolution
C1	Neak Ta as the antagonist; they are normally respected protectors	Before Ep 1	A guardian enforcing a broken contract, not evil
C2	Several Khmer terms in v1 need checking (see each episode's glossary)	Each episode	Native speaker review; keep one glossary
C3	"Graphic designer" is a modern job title	Done	"Illustrator" used in v2.0
C4	Language of voices and text	Before Ep 1	Khmer voices; English and Khmer text
C5	The blood offering in Episode 5	Before Ep 5	Review with the advisor; keep it restrained
B1	Is Episode 1 free, pay-what-you-want or paid?	Before release	
B2	Where to publish (itch.io, own site, both)?	Before release	itch.io is the easiest start for a browser game
B3	Licence: the README says MIT for everything	Before publishing assets	Code open source, art and story all rights reserved